

Orientalism

Predominantly executed by French and British artists, Orientalism describes 19th-century realistic-looking (though not necessarily accurate) paintings of the exotic East, including present-day Turkey, Morocco and Egypt. Subjects include landscapes, harems and slave markets. Although the artists who painted them were of different generations, enthusiasm for the theme was inspired partly by Napoleon Bonaparte's 1798 invasion of Egypt. Artists who explored the theme included Jean-Étienne Liotard (1702–89), Antoine-Jean Gros (1771–1835), Gérôme, Ingres, Delacroix, Théodore Chassériau (1819–56), William Holman Hunt, Auguste Renoir (1841–1919) and Matisse.

The taste expanded to a fashion for Eastern architectural motifs, furniture and interior decoration. Proponents of the Aesthetic movement of the 1860s, who believed in beauty for its own sake, were great enthusiasts for Oriental interiors. For instance, Frederic Leighton (1830–1896) decorated his London home with fountains and mosaic tiles collected on journeys to the East.



Gérôme, *On the Desert*, c.1860